Fostering friendly relations
US President Joe Biden attends a welcoming ceremony hosted by Vietnam's Communist Party General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong at the Presidential Palace in Hanoi in 2023.

Economic achievement

Since 2000, Vietnam's economic growth rate has been impressive, with GDP consistently topping 5 percent growth other than during the Covid pandemic. Vietnam has attracted significant foreign investment, seen a construction boom, and dramatically increased foreign trade. In 2007, it became a member of the World Trade Organization, which opened up new world markets, and since 2020, it has belonged to the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (RCEP), allowing for free trade between ASEAN members and other wealthy economies in East Asia, such as Australia, China, Japan, Korea, and New Zealand.

International tourism, which peaked at 18 million visitors a year before the pandemic, is important: more than 40 percent of Vietnam's gross domestic product is generated by services, including tourism, and the number of first class hotels and restaurants continues to grow. Hanoi is now often cited as one of the top 10 cities in the world to visit. The stunning Ha Long Bay is popular and the tunnels of Cu Chi have been opened up as a tourist attraction. Increasingly, American Vietnam veterans have returned to visit, and even though this is an aging cohort, the Vietnamese consider war tourism to be an expanding market.

Cambodia's fortunes

It has been a less optimistic story in Cambodia, where Prime Minister Hun Sen ruled with an iron fist from 1985–2023, at which point his son and nominated successor Hun Manet took over. (Hun Sen remained in politics as president of the Senate.)